

FREE GUIDE

The 7-Point **AI** Readiness Checklist

A practical guide to evaluate where AI fits in your business — and what to get right before you automate anything.



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Everyone's investing in AI. Almost nobody is ready for it. MIT research found that 95% of generative AI pilots fail to deliver meaningful financial returns. The issue isn't the technology — it's operational readiness. Here are the seven things to get right before you automate anything.

1 Your Processes Are Actually Documented

If you ask three people on your team how a workflow runs and get three different answers, you're not ready to automate it. AI agents execute processes — if the process isn't defined, the agent has nothing to execute. You need a clear, written answer to: *what are the steps, who owns each step, what triggers the next one, and what happens when something goes wrong?*

2 You Know What's Actually Broken

Most businesses have a vague sense that "things are inefficient." That's not enough. Before you automate, pinpoint exactly where time and money are leaking. Where do tasks stall? Where does information get lost between handoffs? The companies that skip process mapping end up automating waste.

3 Your Data Is Clean Enough to Act On

AI agents make decisions based on data. If your data is inconsistent, duplicated, outdated, or scattered across disconnected systems, the agent will make bad decisions — consistently and at scale. Audit your data before you build. It's cheaper to clean a database than to debug an agent working with bad inputs.

4 You Have Clear Success Metrics

"We want to be more efficient" is not a success metric. "Reduce average customer response time from 4 hours to under 30 minutes" is. Define what success looks like in concrete, measurable terms — tied to a business outcome: cost reduction, revenue increase, time saved, or error rate decreased.

5 You've Picked One Workflow — Not Ten

The biggest readiness trap is ambition. The companies seeing real ROI start with one workflow — the one with the highest volume, highest cost, and highest repeatability. They prove value there, build internal expertise, and expand methodically. Trying to automate five workflows simultaneously is a guaranteed way to deliver zero results on all five.

6 Someone Owns It

AI initiatives without clear ownership die slowly. Before you start, answer: Who is accountable for success? Who monitors the agent day-to-day? Who decides when it needs adjusting? This doesn't require a dedicated AI team — but someone needs to be named, empowered, and responsible.

7 Your Team Is On Board

You can build a perfect agent, deploy it into a team that doesn't trust it, and watch it fail anyway. Before you launch, explain what the agent will do, what it won't do, and how it changes people's daily work. Involve the team in process mapping — they know the workflow better than anyone.

What Readiness Actually Looks Like

Example: A 30-person logistics company automating order tracking and exception handling.

Not Ready

- ✗ Tracking process differs by team member
- ✗ Customer data in three unsynced systems
- ✗ "Less chaos" is the success metric
- ✗ Plan to automate everything at once
- ✗ No one owns the initiative
- ✗ Ops team wasn't consulted

Ready

- ✓ Inquiry flow mapped step by step
- ✓ 70% of inquiries are repeatable patterns
- ✓ Data consolidated in one system
- ✓ Goal: 60% auto-resolved, 95%+ accuracy
- ✓ Starting with tracking only — expand later
- ✓ Ops manager owns it, team helped design it

The Bottom Line

AI readiness isn't about whether the technology is good enough — it is. The question is whether your business is prepared to get value from it. Every item on this checklist is fixable. And fixing them doesn't just prepare you for AI — it makes your business run better regardless. The preparation itself is valuable.

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